Threat Intelligence Lab Guide

Thirty-two hands-on exercises, one per video, that walk a single habit from first principles to a working program: start with a question, collect against it, think carefully, and deliver an answer someone can act on.

How to use this guide

Each lab follows the video of the same number. Watch the video first; the lab assumes its vocabulary. Every lab lists a goal, what you need, numbered steps, the artifact you hand in, and a short self-check. Labs build on one another — the requirements you write in Lab 06 are the yardstick for collection in Labs 08–12 and for measurement in Lab 28 — so keep everything in one place.

Time estimates assume you have finished Lab 03 and your environment is running. They are for a careful first pass, not a race.

Rules that apply to every lab

1. **Research identity only.** Never research adversaries from a personal account, a work laptop you rely on, or your home IP. Use the isolated environment and research personas from Lab 03.
2. **Passive by default.** Observe; do not interact. No logging in to adversary infrastructure, no messaging threat actors, no purchasing data, no scanning systems you do not own.
3. **Defang everything you write down.** `hxxp://`, `example[.]com`, `192.0.2[.]10`. Nothing clickable leaves the lab.
4. **Malware lives in the sandbox.** Live samples are opened only inside a disposable, network-isolated VM with a known-good snapshot. Never on a host that matters.
5. **No stolen data.** Do not download, open, or retain breach dumps or leaked credentials. Where a lab calls for closed-source material, use the defanged excerpts in the course pack.
6. **Follow your own policy.** From Lab 05 onward, your written collection-and-handling policy governs. If a step would breach it, stop and note why.

Your lab notebook

Keep one notebook (a Markdown folder or wiki works) with a page per lab. Each page records the date, the requirement it serves, sources used with access time, findings, confidence, and open questions. Store artifacts as `LAB-NN_short-name`. You will reuse these pages in the capstone (Lab 29) and the analytic review (Lab 31).

Course map

PART	THEME	LABS
I	Foundations	01–05
II	Direction, Collection and Processing	06–12
III	Analysis	13–18
IV	Operationalizing Intelligence	19–24
V	Dissemination and the Program	25–28
VI	Mastery	29–32

PART I · LABS 01-05

Foundations

Vocabulary, the intelligence cycle, a safe lab, the adversary landscape, and the ethical and legal limits — everything later work stands on.

VIDEO 01 · WHAT THREAT INTELLIGENCE ACTUALLY IS · 60 MIN

01 Classify one event four ways

Goal. Practice separating strategic, operational, tactical and technical intelligence by audience and decision.

You need. One recent public security event with at least two independent public write-ups (vendor report, government advisory, or reputable press).

STEPS

1. Write a three-sentence neutral summary of the event: who was affected, what happened, what is known.
2. Draw a four-row grid: strategic, operational, tactical, technical. Add columns for audience, the decision it informs, and the specific detail from the event.
3. Fill each row. Strategic: trend or business risk for an executive. Operational: campaign, timing, intent for a security manager. Tactical: TTPs for defenders. Technical: indicators for tooling.
4. Mark each detail as data, information, or intelligence. If it answers no one's question, label it trivia.
5. Note one thing a reader might mistake for intelligence that is really a raw indicator list.

Deliverable. A one-page classification grid with a sentence per row naming the consumer and the decision.

Check yourself. Every row names a real person and a real decision. Nothing in the strategic row requires technical knowledge to understand.

VIDEO 02 · THE INTELLIGENCE CYCLE · 45 MIN

02 Walk one question around the cycle

Goal. Make each stage of the cycle concrete before you have tools to hide behind.

You need. Paper or a blank notebook page. A sample question, e.g. “Is our sector being targeted by ransomware groups this quarter, and through what initial access?”

STEPS

1. Direction: rewrite the question so it is specific, time-bound and answerable. Name who asked and why.
2. Collection: list four sources you would use and what each would contribute.
3. Processing: describe what you would need to normalize, deduplicate or translate before analysis.
4. Analysis: state the competing answers you would weigh and what evidence would separate them.
5. Dissemination: name the product, its format, its length, and its deadline.
6. Feedback: write the two questions you would ask the requester afterward. Then note which stage, if skipped, would hurt most and why.

Deliverable. A one-page cycle diagram annotated with your plan for each stage.

Check yourself. Collection traces back to the question, not to sources you happen to like. Feedback asks whether the answer changed a decision.

VIDEO 03 · BUILDING YOUR THREAT INTELLIGENCE LAB · 3-4 HRS

03 Stand up an isolated analysis environment

Goal. Build the environment every later lab runs in, and prove you can handle a malicious artifact safely.

You need. A host with 16 GB RAM or more; a hypervisor (VirtualBox, VMware, or Proxmox); a Linux analysis VM such as REMnux; MISP or OpenCTI (Docker is fine); a defanged artifact from the course pack.

STEPS

1. Create a dedicated virtual network. The analysis VM gets host-only networking by default; research browsing happens through a separate VM routed via VPN or Tor.
2. Create research personas: a separate email address and browser profile with no link to your real identity. Record them in your notebook, not in the VM.
3. Install the threat intelligence platform and create an organization, a user, and one test event.
4. Install REMnux tooling (or equivalent) in the analysis VM. Take a clean snapshot and name it BASELINE.
5. Transfer the defanged artifact using a password-protected archive (password: infected). Hash it, inspect it with strings and file, and log the results to the platform.
6. Revert to BASELINE and confirm the artifact is gone.

Deliverable. An environment diagram showing networks and trust boundaries, plus a screenshot of the artifact logged in your platform.

Check yourself. You can explain what would reach the internet if the sample tried to call home. The answer should be: nothing.

VIDEO 04 · THE THREAT LANDSCAPE · 90 MIN

04 Profile a documented threat actor

Goal. Describe an adversary through motivation, capability and intent using open reporting only.

You need. One publicly documented actor (nation-state, ransomware group, or hacktivist collective) with at least three independent reports; the MITRE ATT&CK Groups page if one exists.

STEPS

1. Record every name vendors use for the actor and note that names are not proof the same activity is meant.
2. Classify the actor: nation-state, cybercrime, hacktivist, insider or opportunist. Justify it in one sentence.
3. Motivation: what do they want? Cite the evidence.
4. Capability: tooling, custom versus commodity malware, operational tempo, reliance on access brokers or affiliates.
5. Intent and targeting: sectors, regions, victim size, and what changed over time.
6. List three things the reporting does not tell you.

Deliverable. A two-page actor profile with a source table listing publisher, date, and reliability.

Check yourself. Each claim cites a source. You stated at least one gap rather than filling it with assumption.

VIDEO 05 · ETHICS, LAW, AND ANALYST TRADECRAFT · 90 MIN

05 Write your collection-and-handling policy

Goal. Decide in advance what you will and will not collect, engage with, or keep.

You need. Your Lab 03 diagram; your jurisdiction's computer misuse and data protection law summaries; your employer's acceptable use policy if relevant.

STEPS

1. Scope: list the source types you will use and those you will not (e.g. no authenticated access to criminal forums).
2. Engagement: define passive observation, and list prohibited actions: interacting with actors, purchasing, scanning systems you do not own.
3. Leaked data: state how you will handle encountering a breach dump: don't download it, record the reference, escalate.
4. Personal data: set minimization and retention rules for information about individuals.
5. Attribution: set the evidence and review bar before you name any actor in writing.
6. Add an escalation path, sign and date it, and record when you will next review it.

Deliverable. A one-to-two page signed policy saved as LAB-05_policy.

Check yourself. A colleague could use it to answer “may I do this?” without asking you.

PART II · LABS 06–12

Direction, Collection and Processing

Start from a requirement, gather raw material against it from open, closed, internal and commercial sources, and turn it into something analyzable.

VIDEO 06 · INTELLIGENCE REQUIREMENTS AND DIRECTION · 2 HRS

06 Write priority intelligence requirements

Goal. Turn an organization's business into a short, ranked list of answerable questions.

You need. The fictional organization brief: Halden Regional Health, a 4,000-staff hospital group with patient records, medical devices, a payments portal, and a recent cloud migration.

STEPS

1. List Halden's crown jewels and the outcomes that would hurt most: care disruption, data exposure, fraud.
2. Hold a simulated stakeholder interview: for each of CISO, SOC lead, and CFO, write the vague ask and the real question beneath it.
3. Draft eight to twelve candidate requirements in the form: who, what, by when, for which decision.
4. Rank them by impact and likelihood. Keep three to five as PIRs and demote the rest to secondary requirements.
5. For each PIR, write what a satisfactory answer looks like and how you would know it was met.

Deliverable. A PIR table: ID, requirement, stakeholder, decision supported, priority, review date.

Check yourself. Every PIR can be answered “yes”, “no” or with a ranked list. None is “monitor threats”.

VIDEO 07 · INDICATORS, OBSERVABLES, AND THE DATA OF INTELLIGENCE · 90 MIN

07 Enrich and rank raw indicators

Goal. See why context, not volume, makes indicators actionable.

You need. The course pack list of 20 defanged indicators (IPs, domains, hashes, URLs, a registry key, a user-agent, a scheduled-task name); your platform; public enrichment sources (WHOIS, passive DNS, VirusTotal search).

STEPS

1. Import the list into your platform and tag each item by type.
2. Enrich each with first and last seen dates, hosting or ASN, associated malware or campaign, and source.
3. Place each on the pyramid of pain, from hash values up to TTPs.
4. Mark each as stale, likely false positive (shared hosting, CDN, sinkhole), or actionable.
5. Write one line of context per actionable indicator: what to do, where, and for how long.

Deliverable. An enriched indicator table sorted by pyramid level, with a recommended action and expiry date for each.

Check yourself. You flagged at least one indicator that would break production if blocked.

VIDEO 08 · OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE COLLECTION · 2–3 HRS

08 Map malicious infrastructure from open sources

Goal. Pivot from one known-bad domain to related infrastructure, passively and verifiably.

You need. A known-malicious domain from a public advisory; access to passive DNS, crt.sh or another certificate transparency search, and a scanning-data service (Shodan, Censys); your research VM.

STEPS

1. Check that the domain appears in at least one authoritative public report. Record the citation.
2. Passive DNS: list historical resolutions and co-hosted domains, with dates.
3. Certificate transparency: find certificates for the domain and pivot on shared subject fields, issuers or serials.
4. Scanning data: look up the hosting IPs for open services, banners, and JARM or other fingerprints shared with other hosts.
5. Do not visit the domain or IPs directly. Note every query you ran and from which persona.
6. Rate each discovered link as confirmed, probable, or coincidental, and explain why.

Deliverable. An infrastructure graph (platform or diagram) and a pivot log listing source, query, result and confidence.

Check yourself. You can name at least one pivot you rejected as coincidental, such as shared hosting.

VIDEO 09 · THE DARK WEB AND CLOSED SOURCES · 90 MIN

09 Analyze defanged forum content

Goal. Extract intelligence from criminal-forum material without accessing those environments.

You need. The course pack's sanitized forum excerpts: an access-sale post, a ransomware recruitment thread, and a data-leak advertisement. Your Lab 05 policy.

STEPS

1. Re-read your policy. You will not search for, visit, or contact any source named in the excerpts.
2. For each excerpt, record the claim, the actor handle, the price or terms, and the victim description (sector, size, region).
3. Assess credibility: actor reputation signals, specificity, internal consistency, and signs of a scam.
4. Map each item to a PIR from Lab 06. Mark any that matter to Halden.
5. Write what a defender should do if the access-sale post described their organization.

Deliverable. A one-page closed-source assessment per excerpt with a credibility rating and recommended action.

Check yourself. At least one item is judged likely unreliable, with reasons.

VIDEO 10 · TECHNICAL COLLECTION AND TELEMETRY · SETUP 2 HRS + 7 DAYS

10 Deploy a honeypot and mine it

Goal. Generate your own collection and turn it into intelligence rather than a log pile.

You need. A low-interaction honeypot such as Cowrie (SSH/Telnet) on a disposable cloud instance in a dedicated account, never on your home network. A log shipper to your platform or a spreadsheet.

STEPS

1. Deploy the honeypot with no real credentials and nothing of value. Restrict outbound traffic.
2. Run it for at least seven days. Check daily that it is healthy and not being abused to attack others.
3. Extract source IPs, attempted credentials, commands run, and files dropped (hash them; do not run them).
4. Cluster the activity: scanners, credential stuffing, and specific botnet behavior.
5. Write which findings would matter to a defender and which are just background noise.
6. Tear down the instance and record that you did.

Deliverable. A honeypot report with top behaviors, clusters, two detection ideas, and a teardown confirmation.

Check yourself. You separated internet background noise from anything targeted, and said how you know.

VIDEO 11 · THREAT FEEDS, PLATFORMS, AND COMMERCIAL INTELLIGENCE · 2-3 HRS

11 Evaluate feeds against a requirement

Goal. Measure feed value with numbers instead of vendor claims.

You need. Three or four free feeds (e.g. abuse.ch URLhaus and ThreatFox, an OTX pulse set, a CISA feed); one PIR from Lab 06; your platform.

STEPS

1. Ingest a fixed seven-day window from each feed.
2. Relevance: count the share of entries related to your PIR (sector, malware family, or region).
3. Overlap: deduplicate across feeds and compute pairwise overlap percentages.
4. Accuracy: sample 25 entries per feed and check for benign, sinkholed or shared infrastructure to estimate the false-positive rate.
5. Timeliness: for overlapping items, compare when each feed first listed them.
6. Recommend which feeds to keep, which to drop, and what is still missing.

Deliverable. A feed scorecard table with a short recommendation.

Check yourself. Your recommendation would hold up if someone asked "what does this feed answer that the others don't?"

VIDEO 12 · PROCESSING, NORMALIZATION, AND STRUCTURING DATA · 2-3 HRS

12 Normalize, deduplicate, and express in STIX

Goal. Turn messy multi-source collection into clean, shareable structured intelligence.

You need. Your outputs from Labs 07, 08 and 11; Python 3 with the stix2 library, or your platform's STIX export.

STEPS

1. Merge the sources into one table with consistent fields: type, value, first seen, last seen, source, confidence, tags.

2. Normalize: lowercase domains, refang consistently in the data layer, convert timestamps to UTC, and map hashes to SHA-256.
3. Deduplicate and record which sources agree on each item. Use agreement as a correlation signal, not proof.
4. Model as STIX 2.1: Indicator, Infrastructure, Malware and Relationship objects, plus one Report object tying them together.
5. Validate the bundle and import it into your platform to check that it round-trips.
6. Write down any processing step you would automate first.

Deliverable. A validated STIX 2.1 bundle (LAB-12_bundle.json) and a processing log.

Check yourself. Someone else's platform could ingest your bundle with no manual fixes.

PART III · LABS 13–18

Analysis

Where information becomes intelligence: bias, structured techniques, ATT&CK, adversary models, malware, and attribution.

VIDEO 13 · THE ANALYSIS MINDSET AND COGNITIVE BIAS · 90 MIN

13 Analyze ambiguity, then audit yourself

Goal. Catch your own biases in the act.

You need. The course pack scenario: anomalous logins, a phishing report and a data transfer at a manufacturer, with deliberately conflicting evidence.

STEPS

1. Read the scenario once and write your first conclusion with a confidence level. Do not revise it.
2. Re-read slowly and list every piece of evidence with whether it supports, contradicts, or is neutral to your conclusion.
3. Check for confirmation bias, anchoring, mirror-imaging, availability and premature closure. Name the evidence each one affected.
4. Write the strongest case for a different conclusion.
5. Revise your judgment and confidence, and explain what moved.

Deliverable. A bias audit: original judgment, evidence ledger, biases found, revised judgment.

Check yourself. You found at least one bias in your own reasoning, not just a hypothetical one.

VIDEO 14 · STRUCTURED ANALYTIC TECHNIQUES · 2–3 HRS

14 Run an analysis of competing hypotheses

Goal. Weigh explanations systematically, focusing on evidence that rules things out.

You need. A documented attribution question with public reporting on more than one hypothesis, such as an intrusion credited to a state actor but disputed; an ACH matrix template.

STEPS

1. Write at least four mutually exclusive hypotheses, including “unrelated criminal activity” and “false flag”.

2. List 10–15 items of evidence and assumptions. Rate each source's reliability.
3. Score each item against each hypothesis as consistent, inconsistent, or not applicable.
4. Focus on inconsistencies. The leading hypothesis is the one with the least evidence against it.
5. Run a key assumptions check and a short devil's-advocate pass on the leader.
6. Name the evidence that would change your conclusion.

Deliverable. A completed ACH matrix and a one-page narrative of the reasoning.

Check yourself. You can point to the single most diagnostic piece of evidence and say why.

VIDEO 15 · THE MITRE ATT&CK FRAMEWORK · 2-3 HRS

15 Map an intrusion to ATT&CK

Goal. Turn a narrative report into a behavioral profile defenders can act on.

You need. A detailed public intrusion report (e.g. The DFIR Report or a CISA advisory); MITRE ATT&CK Navigator.

STEPS

1. Read the report and extract each discrete action with a quote or citation.
2. Map each action to a technique or sub-technique. Mark uncertain mappings and do not force a fit.
3. Order the techniques by tactic to rebuild the intrusion flow.
4. Build a Navigator layer that color-codes confirmed and uncertain mappings.
5. Write a behavioral profile: the actor's preferred techniques, tooling, and distinctive procedures.
6. List three mappings a less careful analyst might get wrong.

Deliverable. A Navigator layer (JSON) and a one-page behavioral profile.

Check yourself. Every technique ties back to a specific sentence in the source.

VIDEO 16 · ADVERSARY MODELS AND ATTACK FRAMEWORKS · 2-3 HRS

16 Diamond-model a set of intrusions

Goal. Use pivoting to link separate events, and recognize when a link is coincidence.

You need. The course pack set of five intrusion summaries with overlapping infrastructure, tooling and victims.

STEPS

1. Build a diamond for each intrusion: adversary, capability, infrastructure, victim. Note the confidence for each vertex.
2. Place each intrusion on the kill chain to see where each was or could have been stopped.
3. Pivot on each shared vertex (same certificate, same loader, same victim sector) and list the connections.
4. Group intrusions into candidate activity threads and justify each link.
5. Identify one link that looks strong but could be coincidence, and explain why.

Deliverable. Five diamonds, an activity-thread diagram, and a campaign assessment with confidence.

Check yourself. No grouping rests on a single shared commodity tool or a single shared hosting provider.

VIDEO 17 · MALWARE ANALYSIS FOR INTELLIGENCE · 3 HRS

17 Extract intelligence from a sample, safely

Goal. Get the infrastructure, capability, and origin clues an intelligence analyst needs, without full reverse engineering.

You need. Your analysis VM reverted to BASELINE with networking set to an isolated fake-internet such as INetSim; a known sample from MalwareBazaar matching a family you studied. Public sandbox reports for comparison.

STEPS

1. Confirm isolation: no route to the host or the internet. Take a pre-detonation snapshot.
2. Static triage: hashes, file type, imports, strings, packer detection, and YARA matches.
3. Behavioral run: execute and capture process, file, registry and network activity for at least five minutes.
4. Extract intelligence: C2 domains or IPs, persistence, capabilities, and any configuration.
5. Compare with public sandbox reports and family write-ups. Note code reuse or overlaps.
6. List clues to origin and rate how easily each could be planted. Revert the VM.

Deliverable. A malware intelligence note: IOCs (defanged), capabilities mapped to ATT&CK, family assessment, and caveats.

Check yourself. Your note says what the sample does and what it suggests, and is explicit about which is which.

VIDEO 18 · ATTRIBUTION AND TRACKING THREAT ACTORS · 3 HRS

18 Build an attribution assessment

Goal. Reach an attribution judgment with the restraint and confidence language the profession expects.

You need. A documented intrusion set (your Lab 15 or 16 material, or a public case); your ACH method from Lab 14.

STEPS

1. Decide the level you are attempting: activity cluster, known group, or sponsoring entity. Default to the lowest level the evidence supports.
2. Sort the evidence into technical, operational (timing, tradecraft) and contextual (targeting, geopolitics).
3. List evidence for and against, including any signs of a false flag.
4. Run a short ACH across candidate actors.
5. State the judgment using standard estimative language and a confidence level: low, moderate or high.
6. Write what would raise or lower your confidence.

Deliverable. A two-page attribution assessment with an evidence-for-and-against table.

Check yourself. A skeptical peer could follow each step from evidence to judgment, and your confidence is no higher than your weakest critical link.

PART IV · LABS 19–24

Operationalizing Intelligence

Putting analysis to work for hunters, the SOC, responders, vulnerability management, leadership, and deception.

VIDEO 19 · THREAT HUNTING WITH INTELLIGENCE · 2 HRS

19 Design an intelligence-driven hunt

Goal. Turn an actor's known behavior into a testable hunt hypothesis.

You need. Your Lab 15 behavioral profile; sample endpoint and authentication logs from the course pack, or a public dataset such as Splunk BOTS or Mordor.

STEPS

1. Pick one or two techniques from the profile that current detections probably miss.
2. Write the hypothesis: "If [actor] used [technique] here, we would see [observable] in [data source]."
3. Identify the data sources, the time window, and the queries (KQL, SPL or Sigma).
4. Define what counts as a finding, a benign explanation, and a data gap.
5. Run the queries against the sample data and record the results, including null results.
6. Write which result should become a permanent detection.

Deliverable. A hunt plan and report: hypothesis, data, queries, results, and follow-up detections.

Check yourself. A hunt that finds nothing still yields a documented coverage statement.

VIDEO 20 · INTEGRATING INTELLIGENCE INTO SECURITY OPERATIONS · 2 HRS

20 Turn a product into enrichment and a detection

Goal. Get intelligence into the tools a SOC actually uses.

You need. One finished product from earlier labs (Lab 15 profile or Lab 17 note); the Sigma rule format; a SIEM or the sample logs.

STEPS

1. Choose one behavior and one high-value indicator set from the product.

2. Write an enrichment record for analysts: what this is, why it matters, confidence, what to do, and when it expires.
3. Write a Sigma rule for the behavior, with a title, description, ATT&CK tags, false-positive notes and level.
4. Test the rule against the sample logs and tune it for noise.
5. Write a two-line triage note a tier-1 analyst could follow.

Deliverable. An enrichment record, a tested Sigma rule, and a triage note.

Check yourself. The rule's description keeps the context. An analyst seeing the alert knows why it exists.

VIDEO 21 · INTELLIGENCE FOR INCIDENT RESPONSE · 90 MIN, TIMED

21 Deliver rapid intelligence in a live incident

Goal. Produce useful intelligence at incident speed.

You need. The course pack incident injects, released at 15-minute intervals: initial alert, lateral movement, ransom note.

STEPS

1. At each inject, give the incident lead a five-line update within 10 minutes: what we think it is, confidence, what they will likely do next, where else to look, and one recommended action.
2. Use your actor profiles and ATT&CK mapping to predict the next technique.
3. Propose scoping queries for related activity the responders may have missed.
4. At the ransom note, add recovery-relevant intelligence: data-leak site behavior, decryptor availability, and reinfection risk.
5. After the exercise, compare your predictions with the full timeline.

Deliverable. Timestamped updates plus a short post-incident intelligence summary.

Check yourself. Every update was on time. You note which predictions were right and why the others missed.

VIDEO 22 · INTELLIGENCE FOR VULNERABILITY AND RISK MANAGEMENT · 90 MIN

22 Prioritize vulnerabilities by exploitation

Goal. Rank patching by real adversary use, not by severity score alone.

You need. The course pack list of 15 CVEs present at Halden; CISA KEV catalog; EPSS scores; vendor exploitation reporting.

STEPS

1. Record the CVSS score for each CVE and rank them by it.
2. Add KEV status, EPSS score and percentile, public exploit availability, and known actor use.
3. Add Halden context: internet exposure, asset criticality, compensating controls.
4. Re-rank the list and write a one-line justification for every move of more than three places.
5. Write the risk-register entry for the top item.

Deliverable. A side-by-side ranking table (CVSS versus intelligence-led) with justifications and one risk-register entry.

Check yourself. At least one high-CVSS item drops and one medium item rises, and you can defend both.

VIDEO 23 · STRATEGIC INTELLIGENCE AND SUPPORTING LEADERSHIP · 2–3 HRS

23 Write an executive strategic brief

Goal. Inform a leadership decision on a threat trend without technical detail.

You need. One industry (healthcare via Halden, or your own); 12–24 months of public trend reporting; one decision leadership faces, such as budget, insurance or a third-party program.

STEPS

1. State the decision the brief supports in one sentence.
2. Gather trend evidence from multiple sources and separate signal from noise.
3. Add geopolitical or industry context that changes the picture.
4. Write the brief: bottom line up front, three key judgments with confidence, business implications, and options.
5. Remove every acronym and technical term a board member would need explained.
6. Keep it to one page plus an optional appendix.

Deliverable. A one-page strategic brief.

Check yourself. A non-technical reader can state the recommendation after 60 seconds.

VIDEO 24 · COUNTERINTELLIGENCE AND ADVERSARY DECEPTION · 2 HRS

24 Design a honey-token deception

Goal. Plan a deception that reveals adversary activity without exposing you or crossing legal lines.

You need. Halden's environment outline; free canary token generators such as Canarytokens; your Lab 05 policy.

STEPS

1. Choose two attack paths from your Lab 15 or 19 work where a decoy would be touched.
2. Design tokens for each: a fake credential, a decoy document, a cloud key or a DNS token. Specify placement and plausibility.
3. Define what an interaction would reveal (source, timing, technique) and the alert path.
4. Assess the risks: could the token leak real information, mislead staff, or trigger a legal issue?
5. Deploy one token in your lab, trigger it yourself, and capture the alert.

Deliverable. A deception plan with placement, expected adversary interactions, alert flow, risk review, and test evidence.

Check yourself. Nothing in the plan involves actively touching adversary systems.

PART V · LABS 25–28

Dissemination and the Program

Products people use, a program that lasts, communities that share, and measures that prove value.

VIDEO 25 · DISSEMINATION AND INTELLIGENCE PRODUCTS · 3 HRS

25 One analysis, three products

Goal. Match form to audience: executive, analyst and machine.

You need. One finished analysis from Labs 15–18.

STEPS

1. Executive brief: one page, bottom line up front, business impact, a recommended decision, and plain-language confidence.
2. Analyst report: key judgments, supporting evidence, ATT&CK mapping, IOCs (defanged), confidence and gaps, and recommended actions.
3. Machine-readable output: a STIX 2.1 bundle of the indicators and behaviors, with confidence and valid-until fields.
4. Check that all three state the same judgment at the same confidence.
5. Add a TLP marking and distribution list to each.

Deliverable. Three products from one analysis.

Check yourself. The executive brief's first sentence is the answer. The STIX bundle validates.

VIDEO 26 · BUILDING AND STRUCTURING AN INTELLIGENCE PROGRAM · 2-3 HRS

26 Design a program structure

Goal. Turn individual skill into an organizational capability on a realistic path.

You need. Halden or your own organization; your PIRs from Lab 06.

STEPS

1. Assess current maturity on a simple ladder: ad hoc, repeatable, defined, managed, optimized.
2. Define the PIR-driven mission statement.

3. Design the roles for year one and year three: lead, analysts, engineer. List the key skills for each.
4. Choose the platform, tooling and processes, and make one explicit build, buy or outsource call with reasons.
5. Define the product catalog: what, for whom, how often.
6. Show the reporting lines and how the function connects to the SOC, IR, vulnerability management, risk and leadership.

Deliverable. A program design document of no more than four pages.

Check yourself. Every product in the catalog maps to a PIR and a named consumer.

VIDEO 27 · SHARING, COMMUNITIES, AND COLLABORATION · 90 MIN

27 Prepare a product for sharing

Goal. Share useful intelligence without exposing your organization.

You need. Your Lab 25 analyst report; TLP 2.0 definitions; your sector's ISAC sharing guidance.

STEPS

1. Identify what is sensitive about your own organization: victim details, internal hostnames, detection gaps, sources.
2. Redact or generalize each item. Record what you removed and why.
3. Assign a TLP level to the whole product and to any paragraphs that need a different marking.
4. Prepare a STIX version with markings applied.
5. Write a short cover note for the community: what it is, why it matters, what feedback you want.

Deliverable. A redacted, TLP-marked shareable product, a redaction log, and a cover note.

Check yourself. A peer organization could act on it, and an adversary reading it would learn nothing about your gaps.

VIDEO 28 · MEASURING AND IMPROVING THE PROGRAM · 2 HRS

28 Build a measurement framework

Goal. Tie the program's output to the decisions and requirements it serves.

You need. Your Lab 06 PIRs and Lab 26 program design.

STEPS

1. For each PIR, define outcome measures: decisions informed, detections created, response time saved, patches reprioritized.
2. Mark vanity metrics (indicator counts, report volume, feed count) and explain why you will not lead with them.
3. Design a quarterly feedback survey for consumers of no more than five questions.
4. Define the requirements review: cadence, who attends, and what triggers an off-cycle change.
5. Draft the one-slide value summary you would show leadership each quarter.

Deliverable. A measurement framework table, a feedback survey, and a sample value summary.

Check yourself. Each metric would change a decision about the program if it moved.

PART VI · LABS 29–32

Mastery

One complete cycle end to end, the failure modes, reviewing your own judgments, and your path forward.

VIDEO 29 · A FULL INTELLIGENCE CYCLE END TO END · 1–2 WEEKS

29 Capstone: run the whole cycle

Goal. Apply every stage to one real public threat, from requirement to feedback.

You need. Your full lab environment and notebook; a current threat relevant to a chosen organization; a peer or mentor to act as the consumer.

STEPS

1. Direction: agree a requirement with your consumer and write it down.
2. Collection: gather from at least three source types (open, technical, community or commercial) under your policy.
3. Processing: normalize, deduplicate and structure the material in STIX.
4. Analysis: apply ATT&CK, the diamond model and ACH. State your judgments with confidence.
5. Operationalize: produce at least one detection or hunt.
6. Dissemination: deliver the product suited to your consumer, on a deadline.
7. Feedback: gather the consumer's response and write what you would change.

Deliverable. A capstone package: requirement, collection log, STIX bundle, analysis, product, detection, and feedback record.

Check yourself. Your consumer can name the decision your product informed.

VIDEO 30 · WHEN INTELLIGENCE FAILS · 2 HRS

30 Dissect a real intelligence failure

Goal. Locate where in the cycle a documented failure broke, and why.

You need. A documented failure with public post-mortems: a misattribution, a missed warning, or a deception that worked.

STEPS

1. Summarize the case neutrally with sources.
2. Walk it through each stage of the cycle and mark where the process held and where it broke.
3. Separate a wrong judgment made with a sound process from a broken process.
4. Identify the bias, deception, or organizational pressure involved.
5. Name the specific control that would have prevented or caught it.

Deliverable. A two-page failure analysis with a cycle diagram marking the breakpoints.

Check yourself. You avoided hindsight bias: you judged decisions by what was knowable at the time.

VIDEO 31 · TROUBLESHOOTING YOUR ANALYSIS AND JUDGMENTS · 2 HRS

31 Run an analytic-review checklist

Goal. Find and fix weaknesses in your own finished work before it ships.

You need. Your capstone analysis (Lab 29) or the Lab 18 assessment; a peer reviewer if possible.

STEPS

1. Build your checklist: evidence support, bias, confidence calibration, alternatives considered, source reliability, deception, and clarity.
2. Run it against your analysis line by line and record every finding.
3. Swap with a peer. Have them run the same checklist, then compare results.
4. Correct the analysis and keep a change log.
5. Revise the checklist with anything you wish it had caught.

Deliverable. A completed checklist, a corrected analysis, a change log, and your personal checklist v1.

Check yourself. At least one judgment's confidence or wording changed as a result.

VIDEO 32 · BUILDING SKILLS AND WHERE TO GO NEXT · 90 MIN

32 Self-assessment and 90-day plan

Goal. Choose a direction and commit to a practice habit.

You need. Your lab notebook; the course map on page 1.

STEPS

1. Rate yourself 1–5 on each part of the course, citing a lab artifact as evidence for each rating.

2. Choose a specialization: strategic analysis, malware and technical analysis, threat hunting, or actor tracking.
3. List the skills that specialization needs that you lack, and one resource for each.
4. Set a weekly practice routine: analyze one public threat, write one product, and maintain the lab.
5. Write a 90-day plan in three 30-day blocks with a deliverable at the end of each.
6. Pick three researchers or communities to follow, and one certification if it serves your goal.

Deliverable. A skills assessment and a one-page 90-day plan.

Check yourself. Every 30-day block ends with something someone else could read.